Basic Tenets of Indian Philosophy

During the last century or so, an impression has been created in the minds of the educated and patriotic men both in India and in other countries that there are certain fundamental or basic tenets of Indian philosophy, or for that matter, of the Western and the Oriental philosophies as well. When one begins to enquire and examine the claim critically or a little more seriously, one fails to discover any such tenet or principle either in Eastern or Western philosophy which could properly be called as either exclusively Indian or Western, at least in the philosophical thought of these countries. I want to emphasize here the term "philosophical thought," lest it be confused with religious ideas or cultural concepts and beliefs, as is very often done in such a case. I shall a little later attempt to throw some light on the causes that might have led to this widespread belief that there are some fundamental tenets of Indian philosophy as distinguished from the fundamental tenets of Western philosophy. Before I do so, let me first examine the prevalent beliefs about the fundamental tenets of Indian philosophy about which we hear so much of from authorities on Indian philosophy.

A survey of the long history of Indian philosophical thought reveals such strong and undeniable currents and periods of all conceivable movements of thought—idealism and realism, theism and atheism, monism and pluralism, naturalism and super-naturalism—that it is almost impossible to pick up any one of these and exalt it as fundamental or basic. It is often said and popularly believed that Indian thought is dominantly idealistic, and that there was no system of materialistic thought in philosophy. First, this is not true, for we have a very powerful, vigorous, extremely daring system of materialistic philosophy associated with the name of the famous philosopher, Carvaka. Though much of this literature is not available now, enough certainly is known about it through other